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Franksly, I have run out of criticism to heap on the bureaucracy of India which once again features on our cover this week. Perhaps what I can do is to remind you about what I wrote in my Letter from the Editor on our previous cover stories on the bureaucracy.

February 1979: "The mammoth bureaucratic machine, despite its notorious inefficiency and callousness, has infiltrated every walk of life and shows no sign of slackening."

February 2001: "Indian bureaucracy is a blight on the nation. It now exists not to serve the people but to feed itself, and all of us taxpayers have the privilege of supporting this monstrosity."

July 2003: "The famous steel frame of India is now regarded by many as a *steal frame*."

June 2007: "What is required is bold political leadership, which severs the vicious nexus between the politician and the bureaucrat. The need is for drastic surgery, not first aid."

Of course, all this writing has fallen on deaf ears, as the Sixth Pay Commission has blissfully announced a retrospective 42 per cent pay hike for 20 million government servants. This will add Rs 12,561 crore to the Centre's salary bill, taking it to Rs 66,058 crore, with another Rs 18,060 crore to be added as arrears from January 2006. The government's total wage bill will be nearly half the personal income tax collections for 2008-2009.

It is understandable for the private sector to give out 15 to 25 per cent raise for four years running, but such a massive raise for our inefficient bureaucrats makes you wonder about any government's intentions towards good governance.

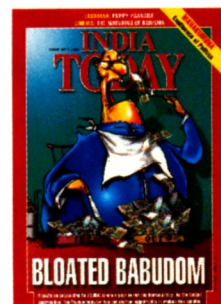
Politicians treat bureaucrats like a large, collective vote-bank whom they dare not displease. Every government has paid lip service in trying to tie our babus' salary increases to efficiency and performance. The Fifth Pay Commission for example wanted 3.5 lakh vacant government posts and a total of 30 per cent of all government posts abolished over a 10-year period. Nothing of the sort happened.

With the Sixth Pay Commission announcements, it is clear that this Government too has given up the ghost of accountability. As a fig leaf, they have appointed an Administrative Reforms Commission with a politician at the head, so it is easy to predict where that exercise will take us.

Our cover story looks at the imbalance between what our government servants earn and what they do in return. Managing Editor Shankar Aiyar who put together our cover package this week, asks, "If the guy holding the carrot does not wield a stick, what happens to accountability?"

I strongly believe that India could grow much faster than the present 8 per cent if this Rs 66,000 crore gorilla was not on the back of us hapless working people. The least the Government can do is to put this gorilla on a diet instead of fattening it more.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)



Our 2001 cover